

Making a difference

Not all versions of Vista are born equal - but some variations are less evident than others. We investigate the hidden features and secret tools in the different editions

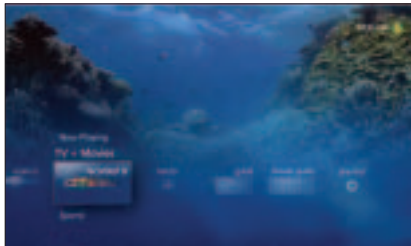
Although most people think of it as a single product, the Windows Vista operating system is available in several versions. And not just one for home and one for work: there are six editions in total, each with a different selection of features and tools. Some differences are obvious, but there are hidden features tucked away inside some versions that can really help to improve the way you use your computer. We'll explain what the different versions include, and point out the secret tools found in each one.



Home Basic is the cheapest version

Basic training

Six versions of Vista sounds like a lot, but in fact there were seven official editions of Windows XP — Home, Professional, Starter Edition, Media Center Edition, Tablet PC Edition and two versions for fancy 64-bit processors. Despite this, though, most people were only ever asked to choose



With Premium you use the Media Center to turn your PC into a personal video recorder

between two: Home and Professional. With Vista, it's more complicated, as it's easy to go online and buy a notebook PC with one of four different versions. Two other versions of Vista are so rare that they can be quickly discounted. Windows Vista Starter is sold at a very low cost. Its only hidden features are limitations: it can only run a handful of programs at once, doesn't work with all processors and can't use hard disks larger than 250GB. Vista

Enterprise Edition has some interesting features and no such limitations, but it's only sold to large businesses so you should never be offered a copy, or a PC running it, for sale.

The cheapest version of Vista that you are likely to be offered is Vista Home Basic. You can pick up a boxed copy for around approximately Rs. 8632 — and although it isn't hobbled like Vista Starter it, too, is characterised more by what it lacks than what it includes. Most notably it can't create DVD discs without extra software, and the backup tool can't schedule backups to run at certain times. Aero (the name for the technology that creates fancy translucent windows and the new Flip 3D effect that appears when you press the Windows Key and Tab) is also missing from Home Basic. The only two hidden features that you might find useful are the Vista Parental Controls, which are included in full, and the Mobility Center, although this is lacking one of its most useful tools — Presentation Settings.



HPremium has an enhanced backup tool



Ultimate has all the features

Premium bonds

The next step up, and the operating system included with most home computers, is Vista Home Premium. This includes everything found in Home Basic, and more besides. Unlike Basic, Home Premium can burn DVD discs and play DVD movies without the aid of any additional software. A boxed copy of Vista Home Premium can be found online for around approximately Rs. 10070.

It's hard not to notice Windows Aero, which gives windows a semi-transparent look and enables the snazzy Flip 3D browser. Two new features that you might not spot, though, are the enhanced backup tool, which can be set to back up files according to a schedule, and the support for touchscreen control. If you are lucky enough to have a tablet PC, a touch-sensitive display or a graphics tablet, Home Premium can make the most of it.

Another obvious addition to Home Premium is Windows Media Center. This provides a simplified way to browse through and play music, videos and digital photos, and connects neatly to Windows Media Player. It also has a number of handy hidden features.